5.6 Plugins to add new layouts

The examples we've touched on in this chapter are a few of the layouts that come with the core D3 library. You'll see a few more in later chapters, and we'll focus specifically on the force layout in chapter 6. But layouts outside of core D3 may also be useful to you. These layouts tend to use specifically formatted datasets or different terminology for layout functions.

5.6.1 Sankey diagram

The Sankey diagram provides you with the ability to map flow from one category to another. It's the kind of diagram used in Google Analytics (figure 5.23) to show event flow or user flow from one part of your website to another. Sankey diagrams consist of two types of objects: nodes and edges. In this case, the nodes are the web pages or events, and the edges are the traffic between them. This differs from the hierarchical data you worked with before, because nodes can have many overlapping connections.

The D3 version of the Sankey layout is a plugin written by Mike Bostock a couple of years ago, and you can find it at https://github.com/d3/d3-plugins along with other interesting D3 plugins. The Sankey layout has a couple of examples and sparse documentation—one of the drawbacks of noncore layouts. Another minor drawback is that they don't always follow the patterns of the core layouts in D3. To understand the Sankey layout, you need to examine the format of the data, the examples, and the code itself.

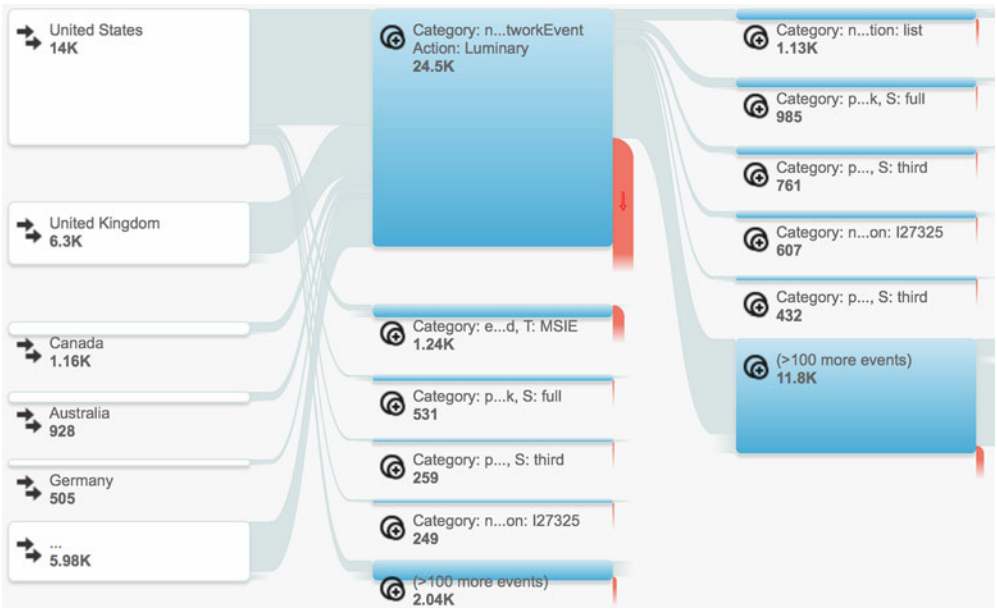


Figure 5.23 Google Analytics uses Sankey diagrams to chart event and user flow for website visitors.